Journal of Business Research 186 (2025) 114991

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Journal of Business Research

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/jbusres

Predictors of social media influencer marketing effectiveness: A comprehensive literature review and *meta*-analysis☆

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
Social media influencers
Influencer marketing
Influencer marketing effectiveness
Literature review
Meta-analysis
Social media

ABSTRACT

Following an increased research focus on influencer marketing and social media influencers (SMIs) in recent years, marketers continue to face the critical challenge of selecting effective SMIs for their campaigns. This difficulty is compounded by the fact that much empirical research is based on single-theory approaches, offering limited predictors and hindering the development of broad practical and theoretical insights. To address this gap, this paper aims to provide a comprehensive and structured overview of predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness through both qualitative and quantitative analysis. Based on a review of 93 articles, covering 108 studies, 56 predictors, and seven dependent measures of SMI marketing effectiveness, this paper introduces a generalized framework for SMI marketing effectiveness and confirms 11 predictors of customer engagement and seven of purchase intention, which are both key measures of effectiveness, clarifying previously inconsistent findings.

1. Introduction

In the last decade, influencer marketing has rapidly emerged as a vital sector in marketing, witnessing widespread adoption among industry professionals. By 2024, expenditure on influencer marketing had reached $35 billion, with forecasts indicating a further 10 % annual growth until 2029 (Statista Market Insights, 2024). Notably, 65 % of marketers had implemented influencer marketing strategies in the previous 12 months, having a 71 % satisfaction rate (Association of National Advertisers, 2021). Marketing through social media influencers (SMIs) has become essential in brands' strategies (Leung, Gu, & Palmatier, 2022).

As the influencer marketing industry has rapidly evolved, it has garnered significant research interest (Cascio Rizzo et al., 2023; Vrontis et al., 2021). Besides defining and conceptualizing the phenomenon, one research stream has focused on empirically investigating the determinants of SMI marketing effectiveness (Hudders et al., 2021; Hugh et al., 2022). Over the past five years, numerous empirical studies of SMI marketing effectiveness have emerged (Aw & Chuah, 2021; Cascio Rizzo et al., 2024; De Vries, 2019; Janssen et al., 2022; Ki & Kim, 2019; M. T. Lee & Theokary, 2021; Leung, Gu, Li, et al., 2022; W. Li et al., 2024; Valsesia et al., 2020). Each of these papers applied single theories, such as persuasion theory (e.g., Evans et al., 2022; Kim & Kim, 2021; Myers et al., 2022), the elaboration likelihood model (e.g., Hughes et al., 2019; M. T. Lee & Theokary, 2021; Pozharliev et al., 2022; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020; Waltenrath et al., 2022), or source credibility (e.g., Cosenza et al., 2014; De Vries, 2019; Lou & Yuan, 2019; Uribe et al., 2016; Yuan & Lou, 2020), from which they derived a countable number of predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness. Various studies have explored how account characteristics, such as the number of followers or SMIs, impact influencer marketing effectiveness (De Vries, 2019; Tafesse & Wood, 2021; Valsesia et al., 2020a; Wang et al., 2019a). Researchers have also examined SMI attributes such as attractiveness (Lou & Yuan, 2019; Torres et al., 2019), expertise (Hughes et al., 2019; Ki & Kim, 2019), and authenticity (Audrezet et al., 2020) in influencing perceptions of SMIs as opinion or taste leaders, thereby enhancing their influence. Additionally, content and posting behaviors have been scrutinized for their role in influencing power and audience engagement (Aw & Chuah, 2021; M. T. Lee & Theokary, 2021). However, the findings have been contradictory across studies. For instance, while some studies have suggested that a higher number of followers positively impacts marketing outcomes such as purchase intention, others have reported contrary findings, indicating that a larger follower count does not necessarily guarantee better marketing results (Park et al., 2021; Peng & Lu, 2024; Valsesia et al., 2020).

Reflecting the diverse theories and findings in this field, the

☆ This research did not receive any specific grant from funding agencies in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors.
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https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2024.114991
Received 10 April 2023; Received in revised form 28 July 2024; Accepted 22 September 2024
Available online 22 October 2024
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academic exploration of SMI marketing effectiveness presents a varied tapestry of hypotheses and results (Hudders et al., 2021). Consequently, this paper aims to distill this intricate landscape by achieving the following three primary objectives: (1) to provide a comprehensive overview of the existing research on predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness, highlighting inconsistencies; (2) to develop a unifying framework that resolves theoretical overlaps; and (3) to resolve inconsistencies in predictors for key SMI marketing effectiveness measures—namely, engagement and purchase intention.

Many literature reviews have sought to address several of these objectives. Yet, prior reviews have primarily been solely qualitative, focusing on the synthesis of the literature on influencer marketing in general (Hudders et al., 2021; Ye et al., 2021) or targeting specific demographics, such as children (De Veirman et al., 2019), specific sectors, such as tourism (Nafi & Ahmed, 2019) or single measures such as consumer engagement (Pradhan et al., 2023). In general reviews, SMI marketing effectiveness has been discussed as one theme in influencer marketing; however, these reviews lack depth in their analysis of SMI marketing effectiveness, given their general focus. For example, in the literature review by Hudders et al. (2021), only 17 out of 154 reviewed papers focused on predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness. Furthermore, quantitative reviews, which could reconcile conflicting study results, remain largely unexplored (Vrontis et al., 2021; Ye et al., 2021). To date, there are two *meta*-analytical reviews on SMIs. Han and Balabanis's (2024) analyze a subset of antecedents from six theoretical foundations, focusing on only two constructs of dependent measures for SMI impact. While Ao et al., (2023) only examine eight SMI characteristics. Other *meta*-analyses in social media research typically focus on singular variables, such as customer engagement or specific strategies, without encompassing the broader scope of influencer marketing (Eisend, 2015; Ismagilova et al., 2021; Santini et al., 2020; Verma et al., 2023).

This paper integrates qualitative and quantitative reviews to fulfill its objectives, thereby aiming to aid the progression of this research field, and offers insights into a crucial question for marketers—namely, that of identifying the attributes that make an SMI effective (Kemp, 2021). More specifically, this paper makes three contributions. First, it systematically structures and synthesizes knowledge in the SMI marketing effectiveness literature. It categorizes such knowledge into four theory clusters, details 56 independent variables, and identifies seven distinct SMI marketing effectiveness measures. The systematic review provides the basis for the development of a comprehensive framework that will aid managers in selecting effective SMIs and navigating the intricacies of this marketing domain. Second, distinct from earlier reviews, this study utilizes *meta*-analytical methods to examine SMI marketing effectiveness predictors, with a focus on customer engagement and purchase intention. It resolves the discrepancies identified in the systematic review, identifying consistent predictors for both engagement and purchase intention as well as ones with divergent effects. The findings suggest that effective SMI selection by managers should be based on their primary goals—that is, to enhance engagement or increase sales. Finally, the findings enhance the understanding of SMI marketing effectiveness by creating a coherent structure in the field. This replaces inconsistencies in previous theories with consistent findings from quantified bivariate relationships. Additionally, it identifies gaps in existing research, paving the way for future investigations.

This paper contains two main sections. The first section outlines a comprehensive literature review of theories and variables on predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness, while the second presents a *meta*-analysis of such predictors.

2. Comprehensive literature review

The literature review begins by detailing the method used to select and code 93 research articles, followed by an exploration of the theories, predictors, and dependent measures in the SMI marketing effectiveness literature. It concludes by integrating overlapping and inconsistent findings into a comprehensive model of SMI effectiveness predictors.

2.1. Data selection and coding

To ensure quality in the review process, this study applied a systematic selection and analysis suitable for fulfilling the research goal and ensuring the reproducibility of research and reasonable coverage of the literature (Fink, 2013; Rowe, 2014). To meet these criteria, this paper followed established search and selection procedures to conduct a systematic approach in screening relevant sources for papers that provide answers about predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness (Paul & Criado, 2020; Snyder, 2019).

To gather relevant studies of SMI effectiveness, a manual search was conducted across 148 marketing journals from the Scorpus Citescore and Chartered Association of Business School rankings for the period covering 2000–2022. This methodology aligned with established academic protocols, prioritizing indexed journals (Billore et al., 2023; Paul & Rosado-Serrano, 2019). Recognizing the extensive literature, the search focused on journals with a CiteScore above 2, following the criteria by Paul and Criado (2020), ensuring comprehensive coverage of significant research in the field.

The final keywords selected for the study were "Social Media Influencer," "Influencers," "Social Media," "Influencer Marketing," and "Influencer Advertising." The keyword selection process involved two steps, following similar methodologies proposed by Arun et al. (2021) and Hudders et al. (2021)—namely, (1) a screening of keywords of 20 relevant papers on SMI marketing effectiveness selected through full-text searches of journals ranked B and higher and (2) consultation of two academic experts in social media and influencer marketing to validate the chosen keywords, ensuring their comprehensiveness and relevance to the research topic.

The search resulted in 208 articles focusing on SMI marketing effectiveness predictors. After removing 36 duplicates, 172 articles remained. 19 qualitative papers, such as those based on grounded theory or framework development, were excluded, as they represent initial theory development without extensive quantitative support (Lou, 2021). Additionally, they did not provide relevant insights for the *meta*-analysis presented in the paper's second section (Audrezet et al., 2020; Kapitan & Silvera, 2016). Moreover, 60 quantitative papers not directly related to SMI marketing effectiveness, such as those focusing on corporate reputation or SMI attachment, were excluded (Delbaere et al., 2021). This refinement left 93 relevant papers, which were included in the comprehensive literature review.

The coding process was conducted in three steps, each incorporating rigorous measures to ensure accuracy (Snyder, 2019). First, the primary author extracted relevant details from each article, including authorship, publication year, theories, quantitative methods, variables, sample sizes, effect sizes, and correlations. Second, the theories were separately devaluated by two authors using criteria from Sandberg and Alvesson (2021) and Sutton and Staw (1995), with internal crosschecks for consistency (Ulaga & Reinartz, 2011). Finally, the authors collaboratively categorized and formed theory clusters as well as constructs in the research discussions. Any disagreements were resolved through elaborate discussions among the three authors to arrive at a consensus coding scheme (Homburg et al., 2017). Appendix A, Table A3 presents a summary of the papers reviewed.

2.2. Results

From the 93 manuscripts analyzed, this paper summarizes four theory clusters across 108 studies (see Appendix A, Table A2), 56 predictors (see Appendix B, Table B1), and seven dependent constructs of SMI marketing effectiveness (see Appendix C, Table C1). There were 401 effect sizes, with 40 incidences of conflicting effects (see Table 2).

2.2.1. Theories about predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness

Analysis of the reviewed papers revealed 22 different theories. Appendix A, Table A1 provides an overview and description of each of these. Most theories have been applied once or twice. To concentrate on the most influential theories, the following discussion focuses on 10 key theories, each chosen for their application in at least three distinct papers. In analyzing these theories, four different perspectives on SMI marketing effectiveness become evident. Therefore, these theories are categorized into four theory clusters.

Theory cluster 1 – Social media influencer perspective: Three theories aiming to explain differences in SMI marketing effectiveness as a result of certain SMI traits or attributes were source credibility theory (Hovland & Weiss, 1951), opinion leadership theory (Katz & Lazarsfeld, 1955), and signaling theory (Zahavi, 1975). These theories position SMIs as central to their analyses, focusing on SMI characteristics as key to marketing effectiveness, although they differ in their focus. Source credibility and opinion leadership theories focus on SMI attributes, while signaling theory takes SMI behavior into account.

The most frequently applied theory among the reviewed papers was source credibility, which suggests that SMIs who are perceived as more credible are also more effective (Cosenza et al., 2014; Ohanian, 1990). The conceptualization of this theory within influencer marketing is heterogeneous. Some studies used Ohanian's (1990) three-dimensional model of trustworthiness, attractiveness, and expertise (Cosenza et al., 2014; Mainolfi et al., 2022), while others focused on only one or two dimensions, such as expertise (Hughes et al., 2019), trustworthiness (Jung & Im, 2021), or expertise and attractiveness (Y. Li & Peng, 2021). Additionally, some studies introduced a four-dimensional model that included similarity, familiarity, or likeability in addition to the three-dimensional model (Duh & Thabethe, 2021; Schorn et al., 2022). The content of SMI, such as message sidedness or sponsorship disclosure, is also considered influential in source credibility (Kim & Kim, 2021; Lee & Johnson, 2022). Kim and Kim (2021) introduced authenticity as a new dimension for source credibility, suggesting that it enhances SMI credibility and marketing outcomes.

Opinion leadership theory claims that there are individuals (called opinion leaders) who exert a superior amount of influence on the attitudes and behaviors of the people around them (Lazarsfeld et al., 1955). Opinion leaders are often associated with network centrality, indicating that well-connected people within a network are likelier to be opinion leaders (Libai et al., 2013). Therefore, several studies in the SMI marketing effectiveness literature used opinion leadership theory to explain the number of followers as a key predictor for marketing outcomes (De Veirman et al., 2017; De Vries, 2019; Valsesia et al., 2020; Wang et al., 2019). However, other studies found leveraging people with a high degree of centrality (well-connected with others) to be a successful strategy to spread information within a network but to not necessarily reflect the level of persuasiveness of these individuals (Hinz et al., 2011). Therefore, even though the number of followers of SMIs directly reflects the degree of centrality of SMIs, several studies regarded other factors, such as originality and uniqueness (Casaló et al., 2020) or creativity (Cheung, Leung, Aw, et al., 2022), as key dimensions of opinion leadership.

Signaling theory focuses on the expression of attributes of SMIs to explain their level of marketing effectiveness. For example, the exposure of body markers or display of muscle alters consumers' perception of the SMI, and therefore, these attributes impact SMI marketing effectiveness (Su et al., 2021).

While each theory offers a distinct explanation of the predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness, they are also interconnected. As SMI credibility positively impacts opinion leadership, source credibility theory reinforces opinion leadership (Jegham & Bouzaabia, 2022). The distinction between both theories was analyzed by De Veirman et al., (2017), who found that the number of followers impacts popularity and likability, which drives SMIs' perceived opinion leadership, but not trustworthiness. Signaling theory, which emphasizes the expression of attributes, complements opinion leadership and source credibility theories. Together, these explain how perceived positive attributes contribute to favorable marketing outcomes while perceived negative attributes lead to adverse results (Hugh et al., 2022; Valsesia et al., 2020).

Theory cluster 2 – Consumer perspective: Three theories—parasocial relationship theory (Horton & Wohl, 1956), uses and gratification theory (Katz et al., 1973), and social influence theory (Kelman, 1961)—explain predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness from the consumer's viewpoint. These theories propose that different aspects of SMI advertising may activate varied consumer relationships, motivations, and information processing, leading to diverse levels of marketing effectiveness.

Parasocial relationship theory describes the relationship between a media character, the SMI, and their followers (Horton & Wohl, 1956; Labrecque, 2014). Such relationships make followers susceptible to the persuasion of SMIs and are therefore important to achieve higher marketing effectiveness in terms of brand attitude, engagement, and purchase intention (De Veirman et al., 2017; Evans et al., 2017). Most recent theorization suggest *trans*-parasocial relationship which governs the relationship between SMI and followers (Lou, 2021). Due to the absence of a universally accepted definition of antecedents for parasocial relationships, the derived predictors vary widely. For example, some scholars argued that SMI characteristics with between two and four dimensional conceptualization, such as attractiveness and similarity (Sokolova & Kefi, 2020); attractiveness, credibility, and prestige (Aw & Chuah, 2021); or expertise, attractiveness, trustworthiness, and similarity (Yuan & Lou, 2020), are antecedents of parasocial relationships. Other predictors analyzed include SMI content characteristics such as quality and informational text (Cheung et al., 2022) or fairness (Yuan & Lou, 2020).

Uses and gratification theory highlights the crucial role of consumer motivation in engagement with SMIs. It suggests that SMIs' ability to meet consumer needs—information, entertainment, or social interaction—significantly influences marketing outcome (Ruggiero, 2000). Empirical research shows that SMI content perceived as entertaining, informative, interactive, or personally rewarding enhances marketing effectiveness. (Cheung, Leung, Yang, et al., 2022; Myers et al., 2022).

Social influence theory explains how consumers' decisions are affected by others (Cialdini & Goldstein, 2004). Research identifies several criteria for susceptibility to social influence, but without consensus (Book et al., 2016), leading to diverse predictors. Tafesse and Wood (2021) suggest followers are influenced by SMIs perceived as popular, credible, or relatable. Similarly, Cheung et al. (2022) identify attractiveness and expertise as key drivers, while Sánchez-Fernández and Jiménez-Castillo (2021) argue that cognitive and emotional attachment predict SMI influence and marketing effectiveness.

Across these theories, social influence theory intersects with parasocial relationships, suggesting that stronger parasocial bonds enhance social influence (Cheung, Leung, Aw, et al., 2022). Parasocial relationships fulfill the need for social interaction, as outlined in uses and gratification theory, intensifying consumer gratification and fostering stronger relationships, thereby boosting SMI marketing effectiveness (Dolan et al., 2019; McQuail, 1994). However, this argument has not yet been empirically explored.

Theory cluster 3 – Congruence: The key idea of the congruence theory cluster concerns consumers' cognitive preference for similarity, which is also the basis for the similarity–attraction theory and the balance theory (Byrne, 1971; Festinger, 1957; Heider, 1958). Both balance theory and similarity–attraction theory share a central idea, yet they have different focal points. Balance theory primarily focuses on psychological consistency, while similarity–attraction theory emphasizes the role of similar characteristics. Within the influencer marketing literature, similarity, or consistency, increases SMIs' influence and SMI marketing effectiveness (Argyris et al., 2021; Belanche et al., 2021; Mettenheim & Wiedmann, 2021). Many different dimensions of congruence, such as the similarity

Table 1
Overview of theories and predictors (independent variables).

	Theory cluster 1: SMI Perspective				*Theory cluster 2: Consumer Perspective*								*Theory cluster 3 Congruence*								*Theory cluster 4 Persuasion*		
	Source Credibility Theory	Opinion Leadership Theory	Signaling Theory	Speech Act Theory	Attention Economic Theory	Theory of Planned Behavior	U&G Theory	Social Influence Theory	Parasocial Relationships	Social Identity Theory	Social Capital Theory	Social Exchange Theory	Attribution Theory	Meaning Transfer Theory	Attachment Theory	Cognitive Dissonance Theory	Balance Theory	Similar-Attraction Theory	Social Adaptation Theory	Self-Congruity Theory	Persuasion Knowledge Model	Comm. / Persuasion Matrix	Elaboration Likelihood Model
WHO																							
Account characteristics																							
Number of follower	x	x	x					x			x			x				x			x		x
Number of followee		x	x					x			x												
Likes to follower ratio	x																						
Duration					x																		
Verification																							
Personal characteristics																							
Gender	x								x	x								x					
Expertise	x	x				x			x			x						x			x	x	x
Attractiveness	x								x					x	x			x			x	x	x
Prestige									x														
Authenticity	x											x											
Familiarity	x																				x		
Authoritative	x																	x					
Approachable	x																	x					
Likeability	x																				x		
Trustworthiness	x					x			x									x			x	x	
Credibility	x	x				x	x		x												x		x
Openness[1]																							
Conscientiousness[1]																							
Agreeableness[1]																							
Extraversion[1]	x																	x					
Congruence																							
Similarity	x	x				x			x	x		x			x			x	x	x	x	x	x
Ideal Self-congruence	x								x									x	x				x
Brand congruence	x												x	x					x				x
Product congruence	x													x		x	x				x		
Cultural congruence																				x			
WHAT																							
Content Style																							
Informative and functional	x	x					x	x	x													x	x
Hedonic and emotional	x	x		x				x			x												x
Entertaining	x						x															x	
Original	x	x																					
Creative		x						x	x														
Unique		x																					
Inspirational	x																	x					
Sided									x														x
Distributive fair	x								x														
Informational fair	x								x														
Interpsonal fairness	x								x														
Procedual fairness	x								x														
Content Scope																							
Interaction	x						x																
Personal-relevance content		x									x												
Domain of interest								x															
Intimate Disclosure	x								x					x									x
Sponsorship disclosure	x						x														x		
Smile																							
Tattoo	x																						
Display of muscle			x																				
Giveaway	x																						x
Social status																		x					
Social presence															x								
HOW																							
Ways of display																							
Quality	x	x						x	x									x					x
Quantity	x	x			x			x															
Ways of expression																							
Message construal[2]																							
External narrative				x																			
Internal analysis				x																			
Language preciseness																							x
Language interactivity																							x
Language closeness	x	x																					x

[1]Derived from big five personality framework.
[2]Derived from influence framework.

Table 2
Overview of effect sizes collected from across 101 studies [colored print preferred].

Dependent Variables	Brand awareness			Attitude towards ad			Brand attitude			Product attitude			Customer engagement intention			Purchase intent			Customer engagement action		
CATEGORY																					
Construct																					
Independent Variables																					
	-	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**
WHO																					
Account characteristics																					
Number of follower						*3*	*1*	*2*	*2*		*1*	*4*	*5*	*1*	*2*	*1*	*4*	*9*	*2*	*1*	*7*
Number of followee													*3*		*1*						
Likes to follower ratio													*1*		*1*						
Duration															*1*						
Verification																	*1*				
Personal characteristics																					
Gender														3	2						
Expertise			2					2	1		1			4	2		8	8		2	
Attractiveness			2						4		1			2	2	1	4	11			
Prestige																		1			
Authenticity									1						2			1			
Familiarity															1						
Authoritative																		1			
Approachable																	1				
Likability													1		2		2	1			
Trustworthiness	2								3			1			1		1	6			
Credibility														2	6		2	4			
Openness																		1			
Conscientiousness																		1			
Agreeableness																	1				
Extroversion																	1	2			
Congruence																					
Similarity		2			1						1				6		10	15			
Ideal self-congruence						1									1		4	5			
Brand congruence							1		1				2			1		6			
Product congruence						4				1		3	1		3	1		3			
Cultural congruence						1							1								
WHAT																					
Content Style																					
Informative and functional		1												7	1			6		2	1
Hedonic and emotional														1	3			1	1	1	2
Entertaining		1												1			2				
Original															2			3			
Creative														1	5						
Unique															1		1				
Inspirational																	1				
Sided							1	1					1		1		2	1			

- = negative effect, ns = not significant, + = positive effect Inconsistent result

(*continued on next page*)

Table 2 (*continued*)

Dependent Variables	Brand awareness			Attitude towards ad			Brand attitude			Product attitude			Customer engagement intention			Purchase intent			Customer engagement action		
CATEGORY																					
Construct																					
Independent Variables																					
	-	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**	**-**	**ns**	**+**
WHAT																					
Content Style																					
Distributive fair												1									
Informational fair											1										
Interpersonal fair											1										
Procedural fair												1									
Content Scope																					
Interaction									1						2		1	2			
Personal-relevance content															1						
Domain of interest														1							
Intimate disclosure								1						1		2	2	4			
Sponsorship disclosure				1		1	1			1			2	2	2	4	4	2	2	1	1
Smile									1									1			
Tattoo														1	1						
Display of muscles																2	2				
Giveaway																					1
Display of extroversion																					
Social status											1						1				
Social presence															1						
HOW																					
Ways of display																					
Quality														7	13		2	3			
Quantity													1	2	1			1			
Message construal															1			1			
External narrative																					1
Internal Analysis																			1		
Language preciseness														1							
Language interactivity															1						
Language closeness															3						

- = negative effect, ns = not significant, + = positive effect Inconsistent result

between an SMI and their followers (Lou & Yuan, 2019a), the congruence of a product and a SMI (Torres et al., 2019) and a brand and a SMI (Kim & Kim, 2021), as well as the cultural similarity between a SMI and their followers (Xu (Rinka) & Pratt, 2018), have been mooted as driving marketing effectiveness.

Theory cluster 4 – Persuasion: Persuasion theories in communication examine the interplay of the sender, the message content, and the receiver and conceptualize persuasion as a process of human information processing. Depending on persuasion theory, different factors as well as mechanisms of the sender, content, and receiver lead to various degrees of processing ease and, therefore, to different levels of persuasion. There are two main theories, the persuasion knowledge model (Friestad & Wright, 1994) and the elaboration likelihood model (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Both theories center on persuasion, with persuasion knowledge model outlining strategies for coping with persuasion and elaboration likelihood model delving into the processing mechanisms of persuasive messages.

Persuasion knowledge model suggests that consumers have a certain awareness or understanding of the tactics and motives behind persuasive messages, such as advertising or sponsorship disclosures, which in turn influence their responses to these messages. SMIs' capacity to mitigate the negative impact of persuasive messages contributes to variations in their marketing effectiveness. Therefore, the papers reviewed that utilized persuasion knowledge model all focused on defensive responses from sponsorship disclosure (Evans et al., 2018; Kim & Kim, 2021; Saternus et al., 2022). They found that factors such as the

number of followers (Kay et al., 2020) or transparency (Woodroof et al., 2020) may moderate or reverse these negative effects.

Elaboration likelihood model suggests that the effectiveness of an SMI's persuasive message depends on the individual's ability and motivation to process the information and the route through which the information is processed (Ki & Kim, 2019; M. T. Lee & Theokary, 2021; Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Different factors impact receivers' ability and motivation—for example, language expressions (Aleti et al., 2019), the display of information (Pozharliev et al., 2022), the platform (Hughes et al., 2019), and congruence (Mettenheim & Wiedmann, 2021).

Summarizing the theory clusters, existing research applies theories on senders (*theory cluster 1*), receivers (*theory cluster 2*), the relationship between senders and other actors within SMI advertising (*theory cluster 3*), and the processing of SMI advertising messages (*theory cluster 4*) to derive predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness. For many theories, there is no consensus on the conceptualization of predictors for SMI marketing effectiveness, making clear demarcations between theoretical explanations for predictors difficult to establish. For example, there is elaborate research on expertise being a predictor of SMI marketing effectiveness because it makes SMIs more credible, according to the source credibility theory (Cosenza et al., 2014; Ki et al., 2020; Lou & Yuan, 2019); at the same time, it has also been found to be a key identifier for opinion leaders (Gomes et al., 2022). Simultaneously, while source credibility fosters parasocial relationships, the effect of expertise is nonsignificant (Yuan & Lou, 2020); however, according to elaboration likelihood model, expertise shows an effect depending on the degree of involvement (Hughes et al., 2019). This theoretical unclarity is the source of the many inconsistent results that are summarized in the following sections, where the three key areas of inconsistencies are discussed in more detail and partially quantitatively resolved for two SMI marketing effectiveness measures, which are engagement and purchase intention.

2.2.2. Classification of predictors, dependent variables, and summary of effects

This paper identifies 56 conceptually distinct predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness through an analysis of 108 studies and thematically groups them into seven constructs, which are further condensed into three overarching categories.

The first category focuses on predictors centered on the SMI (i.e., *who* this person is). We define three constructs in this category: (i) *account characteristics*, which cover predictors that feature social media user account-related metrics, such as the number of followers and duration since the account has been registered; (ii) *personal characteristics*, which encompass the personal attributes of SMIs, such as gender, attractivity, or expertise; and (iii) *congruence*, which contains features delineating the level of similarity between SMIs and the different parties involved—for example, their followers, brands, or products. The second category pertains to SMI content (i.e., *what* SMIs communicate). Two constructs, *content style* and *content scope*, form this category. Content style incorporates predictors that describe the content, such as informative and functional or hedonic and emotional. Content scope constitutes predictors specifying the topics that SMIs share, such as the disclosure of sponsorships. The last category attends to factors illustrating the way of communication (i.e., *how* SMIs communicate). Two constructs were identified in this category. First, the *way of display* encapsulates the aesthetics and frequency of content communication. Second, the *way of expression* outlines attributes of SMIs' verbal communication, such as the precision of language or the level of abstraction in their messages. Appendix B, Table B1 presents an overview and definition of the 56 predictors.

Many predictors were only studied once, with most studies concentrating on similarity, number of followers, expertise, and attractiveness. There was no exclusivity of theory on predictors. A single predictor was often explained by multiple theories, and as outlined in the theory cluster section, clear boundary conditions for the applicability of each theory are yet to be developed. An overview of how predictors map on theories is presented in Table 1.

Within the reviewed literature, SMI marketing effectiveness was conceptualized using seven constructs—namely, brand awareness, attitude toward ads, brand attitude, product attitude, customer engagement intention, purchase intention, and customer engagement action (see Appendix C, Table C1). There exists extensive marketing research on all seven constructs. A more detailed elaboration on the seven dependent constructs is presented in Appendix C.

Most existing research focuses on engagement and purchase intention. Across the studies reviewed, engagement intention was part of 32 studies, and 48 studies conceptualized SMI marketing effectiveness using purchase intention. Other dimensions were rarely tested, and key predictors for those dependent variables are yet to be established.

Table 2 depicts the effects of predictors on SMI marketing effectiveness collected from the reviewed papers. The study results of many predictors were contradictory. In total, we counted 40 occurrences of inconsistent results. For dependent measures of SMI marketing effectiveness, in a limited number of studies, the results remained consistent. For example, the best predictor for achieving brand awareness was SMI expertise and attractiveness. Furthermore, attitude toward ads was driven by follower count, ideal-self, and product congruence, while sponsorship disclosure negatively impacted it.

For customer engagement and purchase intention, numerous predictors were repeatedly tested, but the results were frequently inconsistent. Therefore, for the two SMI marketing effectiveness variables, customer engagement and purchase intention, a *meta*-analytical review is required to improve the quality of the research findings. An examination of the most significant inconsistencies in the literature revealed conflicting hypotheses and results, even with similar methodologies. The three predictors with the greatest inconsistencies were number of followers (22 effect sizes spread across three dimensions), expertise (22 effect sizes across three dimensions), and similarity (31 effect sizes across three dimensions).

According to opinion leadership theory, the number of followers is essential for engagement, signifying an SMI's potential reach (Valsesia et al., 2020). This perspective is reinforced by social network theory, which suggests that an increase in connections amplifies an SMI's impact and the likelihood of user engagement within the network (Wang et al., 2019). From the standpoint of source credibility and signaling theory, a larger follower count is seen as a marker of credibility, reflecting the SMI's popularity, status, and reputation (Leung, Gu, Li, et al., 2022). Conversely, other scholars have argued that engagement with SMI content hinges on perceptions of personal, authentic, and relatable SMIs (Belanche et al., 2021; Janssen et al., 2022; Lou & Yuan, 2019). As an SMI's popularity rises, the sense of personal connection and perceived trust may wane, potentially reducing engagement (Chen et al., 2022). As there are arguments for the positive and the negative impact of the number of followers on engagement, several scholars have suggested that SMIs' number of followers has only a positive effect on engagement when regarded in relationship with the number of followees (De Vries, 2019; Peng & Lu, 2024). However, whether a high or low ratio of follower count to followee count is better for engagement and purchase intention remains unsolved, due to opposing results (De Veirman et al., 2017; Valsesia et al., 2020, Peng & Lu, 2024). Steils et al. (2022) suggested an inverted U-shaped relationship between follower count and engagement, moderated by sponsorship disclosure, that could address previous inconsistencies. Given the diverse discussion on the relationship between the number of followers and engagement, a similar dynamic could be expected for purchase intention. However, most studies reported the positive impact of follower count, supporting its influence on SMI credibility, and thus, consumer purchase intention (Janssen et al., 2022; Pittman & Abell, 2021; Weismueller et al., 2020). Conversely, studies advocating a negative effect proposed that micro-influencers, perceived as more authentic and trustworthy, have a greater persuasive impact, leading to higher purchase intention,

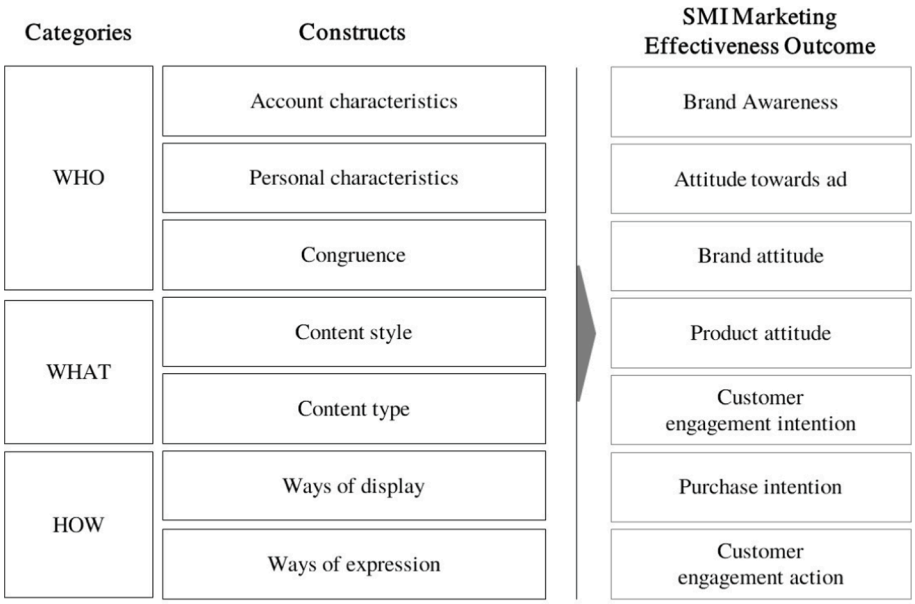

Fig. 1. Generalized SMI marketing effectiveness model.

especially in hedonic consumption and SMIs in the sustainability sector (Park et al., 2021; Pittman & Abell, 2021). Other studies investigated how different drivers may lead to varying impact when combined with the number of followers, such as arousal language or consumer mindset which differs for macro vs. micro SMIs (Rizzo et al., 2024; W. Li et al., 2024).

Regarding expertise as a predictor, the debate centers on whether it has a positive impact or not, with no studies indicating a negative effect. As a fundamental element of source credibility, expertise is believed to influence trust in SMI content, leading to increased engagement and purchase intentions. However, some studies reported insignificant results, with limited explanations for these findings (Duh & Thabethe, 2021; Saima & Khan, 2021). One suggested reason relates to the age of the population studied; for instance, Fernandes et al. (2022) found expertise to be a significant predictor of older consumers. Hughes et al. (2019) contended that expertise is primarily relevant for content aimed at raising awareness. This perspective is supported by the positive influence of expertise on brand awareness (Lou & Yuan, 2019).

Inconsistencies in the predictor of similarity occurred mainly in the context of purchase intention, with 10 effect sizes being nonsignificant and 15 showing positive results. Conversely, for engagement, the existing literature uniformly identified the significant positive effect of similarity in six studies. Regarding purchase intention, the impact of similarity depends on various mediators and moderators. wo studies suggest that parasocial relationships mediate the effect, with stronger relationships enhancing purchase intention (Bu et al., 2022; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). Other studies indicate trust as a mediator, with source credibility driving increased purchase intention (Lou & Yuan, 2019a; Naderer et al., 2021). Closeness between SMI and followers inversely moderates the similarity–purchase intention relationship, with similarity positively affecting purchase intention only when closeness is low (Taillon et al., 2020). Similarity positively affects purchase intention only when closeness is low. Involvement also moderates this effect, though its impact is debated. Mettenheim and Wiedmann (2020) observed that similarity to be significant in high-involvement scenarios, contrasting with the common view of social media as a low-involvement environment (Hughes et al., 2019). Balabanis and Chatzopoulou (2019) noted the significance of similarity to moderately involved consumers. These studies did not focus on a specific platform, with participants asked about the last platform they visited. The age groups in these studies differed significantly; while Mettenheim and Wiedmann (2020) concentrated on students, Balabanis and Chatzopoulou (2019) included participants with a broader age range.

2.2.3. *Proposed generalized SMI marketing effectiveness model*

Based on the findings, this paper has developed a comprehensive SMI marketing effectiveness model that includes all the variables reviewed. This model features three categories, seven dependent measures of SMI marketing effectiveness, and 56 predictors. The activation of these predictors, whether joint, selected, or singular, can result in varied dimensions of marketing effectiveness. Fig. 1 illustrates this generalized model.

This model echoes McGuire's (2001) communication persuasion model in assuming a multitude of factors that collectively influence varying levels of marketing outcomes. However, the generalized SMI marketing effectiveness model has been specifically crafted for the influencer marketing context. It was constructed through a comprehensive, bottom-up approach grounded in an extensive review of the existing literature on SMI marketing effectiveness.

Second, even though the three categories of *who*, *what*, and *how* resemble the source and message factors in the communication and persuasion model, McGuire's communication persuasion model is a classical communication model that evaluates only how mass media communication persuades consumers and presupposes marketer control over most input factors (McGuire, 2001). In contrast, influencer marketing involves marketers selecting an SMI, thereby largely controlling inputs such as message, channel, and receiver. Thus, the SMI marketing effectiveness model concentrates on evaluating factors accessible to marketers, such as SMI attributes and the style and scope of the content.

Third, in SMI marketing effectiveness, it is crucial to highlight the predictors related to delivery style and expression. The generalized SMI marketing effectiveness model addresses this by incorporating the HOW category, which is absent from McGuire's communication persuasion model, thereby offering a more comprehensive framework for influencer marketing.

Finally, the seven levels of marketing effectiveness in the model correspond to four of the seven levels in McGuire's communication persuasion model. While McGuire's framework suggests a stepwise progression from one persuasion level to another, correlating with stages of consumer information processing, the influencer marketing context centers on engagement with the SMI that does not always follow a stepwise trajectory. Due to social media algorithms favoring content

Table 3
Meta-analysis of SMI predictors of customer engagement.

Predictors			K	N	ρ	95 % Confidence Interval		Q	I^2
						lower	upper		
WHO	Account characteristics	Number of followees	4	10,079	−0.10	0.24	0.05	7.04	57.40 %
		Number of followers	5	11,303	−0.08**	−0.13	−0.04	2.22	0 %
	SMI personal characteristics	Expertise	6	1,395	0.34*	0.07	0.57	76.92***	93.50 %
		Attractiveness	4	1,377	0.21**	0.10	0.31	4.74	36.70 %
		Authenticity	2	1,286	0.49	−0.90	0.99	2.3	45.40 %
		Credibility	8	4,458	0.55**	0.05	0.83	9.35	32.45 %
		Likeability	3	932	0.25*	0.07	0.41	3.28	39.20 %
	Congruence	Similarity	6	2,884	0.51**	0.36	0.63	35.93***	88.90 %
WHAT	Content style	Informative and functional	8	2,421	0.33***	0.22	0.43	14.23	48.60 %
		Hedonic and emotional	3	9,209	0.09***	0.09	0.09	16.25	32.82 %
		Original	2	1,088	0.56**	0.51	0.61	422	38,20 %
	Content scope	Sponsorship disclosure	6	18,101	0.03	−0.20	0.27	4.46	48.00 %
HOW	Ways of display	Quality	15	4,969	0.28***	0.22	0.34	60.49***	76.90 %
		Quantity	3	2,578	0.21	−0.11	0.49	24.79**	91.90 %
	Ways of expression	Language psych. closeness	3	318	0.57**	0.48	0.65	0.52	0.00 %

K = Number of studies; N = Number of observations; ρ = Corrected population correlation; Q=Cochran's Q; *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$.

with high engagement, engagement can precede brand awareness, which may then affect purchase intention (Han et al., 2020).

3. Meta-analytical review

The section begins with an overview of the *meta*-analytical methodologies and techniques used, followed by an assessment of the presence and strength of bivariate relationships between SMI marketing effectiveness predictors and key metrics such as customer engagement and purchase intention. Notably, existing research often shows inconsistent and inconclusive results regarding these predictors (see Table 2). While consensus exists, the effect sizes still vary. Thus, this *meta*-analytical review seeks to validate and quantify these relationships.

3.1. Meta-analytical techniques

This *meta*-analysis of SMI marketing effectiveness in terms of customer engagement incorporates data from 32 papers and 15 predictors, while the analysis focusing on purchase intention draws from 48 papers and 13 predictors. For other dependent measures of SMI marketing effectiveness, there were too few studies available for a *meta*-analytical approach.

To determine the effect sizes, this paper follows established *meta*-analytical procedures applied in previous *meta*-analytical studies (Babić Rosario et al., 2016; Santini et al., 2020). Primarily, Pearson's correlation coefficients were extracted from each article, since they were the most frequently used metric. Where correlation coefficients were not available, mean differences, F-, or t-values were first converted into correlations (Hunter & Schmidt, 1991) and then transformed into Fisher's z (Olkin & Finn, 1995).

The *meta*-analysis utilized a random effects model, applying inverse variance weighting to pool effect sizes and the restricted maximum likelihood method to estimate heterogeneity variances (DerSimonian & Kacker, 2007; Hartung & Knapp G., 2003; Viechtbauer et al., 2015). Between-study heterogeneity was assessed using Cochran's Q, which evaluates the likelihood of observed heterogeneity occurring by chance, and the I2 statistic, which reflects the percentage of total variation due to heterogeneity (Cochran, 1954; Higgins & Thompson, 2002).

3.2. Results and discussion of customer engagement

Of the 15 predictors included in the *meta*-analysis, 11 were significantly related to SMI customer engagement. Table 3 presents the results of the *meta*-analysis of bivariate correlations.

In particular, the account characteristic of number of followees' relationship to customer engagement was nonsignificant ($\rho = -0.10$, p = *n.s.*), while the account characteristic of number of followers was negatively correlated with SMI customer engagement ($\rho = -0.08$, $p = 0.006$). This finding suggests that once an SMI has established a follower community with a significant number of followers and is recognized as an SMI, an additional number of followers leads to a deterioration of engagement within the SMI follower community that has formed. Practitioners largely agree with this result, since the measured engagement rate for SMIs in terms of likes, comments, and reposts on Instagram and Twitter supports this fact (Trend, 2020). Academics also support this finding, explaining, based on construal level theory, that when followers' communities are limited, followers are more homogeneous, compared to large follower communities. Therefore, it is easier for SMIs to uphold a closer and more intense connection with their followers (Kay et al., 2020). Parasocial identification and relationships are stimulated, making followers more susceptible to SMIs' influence (Horton & Richard Wohl, 1956b). On the contrary, when the number of followers rises, the follower community grows heterogeneous, and it becomes difficult for SMIs to uphold a close connection with all followers, whereby engagement declines (De Vries, 2019; Kay et al., 2020).

Apart from authenticity ($\rho = 0.49$, p = *n.s.*), all other predictors of SMIs' personal characteristics showed a significant positive relationship with customer engagement (expertise: $\rho = 0.34$, $p = 0.003$; attractiveness: $\rho = 0.21$, $p = 0.008$; credibility: $\rho = 0.55$, $p = 0.02$; and likeability: $\rho = 0.25$, $p = 0.08$). The positive relationship between expertise, attractiveness, credibility, and likeability further underlines the validity of the source credibility theory (Han & Balabanis, 2024; Pornpitakpan, 2004). However, contrary to most practitioners' beliefs, authenticity, one of the most frequently named success factors among SMIs and marketing professionals, was not significantly correlated with marketing effectiveness in terms of customer engagement and attitude (Audrezet et al., 2020; Han & Balabanis, 2024).

In terms of congruence, similarity was strongly positively correlated with customer engagement ($\rho = 0.51$, $p = 0.008$). This finding corroborates previous results regarding the positive effect of congruence on consumer behavior (Choi & Rifon, 2012). By establishing relatedness to followers, and thus eliciting perceived similarity, SMIs achieve emotional bonds with followers and stimulate engagement (Ki et al., 2020).

Of the predictors of content styles, all three had a positive relationship with customer engagement (informative and functional: $\rho = 0.33$, p

Table 4
Meta-analysis of SMI predictors of purchase intention.

Predictors			K	N	ρ	95 % Confidence Interval		Q	I^2
						lower	upper		
WHO	Account characteristics	Number of followers	15	9,133	0.12	−0.07	0.39	45.97*	28.30 %
	SMI personal characteristics	Attractiveness	16	8,931	0.23***	0.14	0.33	21.39	25.40 %
		Expertise	16	5,922	0.18**	0.08	0.27	26.16	29.30 %
		Credibility	6	2,268	0.27*	0.02	0.49	16.10	51.61 %
		Trustworthiness	8	3,241	0.23	−0.01	0.44	20.87***	96.40 %
	Congruence	Brand congruence	4	3,663	0.24***	0.19	0.28	1.31	0.00 %
		Ideal Self-congruence	5	2,855	0.07	−0.01	0.14	15.24*	60.60 %
		Similarity	19	10,066	0.15***	0.09	0.22	137.13***	86.90 %
WHAT	Content style	Informative and functional	6	2,364	0.36***	0.28	0.44	15.89	25.70 %
	Content scope	Interaction	4	6,415	0.09	−0.17	0.34	49,50**	93.80 %
		Intimate Disclosure	8	2,937	0.18	−0.11	0.44	19,52*	63.66 %
		Sponsorship disclosure	25	12,836	−0.23***	−0.32	−0,13	8.48	37.56 %
HOW	Ways of display	Quality	5	1,150	0.42**	0.30	0.54	12.88	20.30 %

K = Number of studies; N = Number of observations; ρ = Corrected population correlation; Q = Cochran's Q; *p < 0.05, **p < 0.01, ***p < 0.001.

< 0.001; hedonic and emotional: ρ = 0.09, $p < 0.001$; and original: ρ = 0.56, $p = 0.009$). Interestingly, informative and functional content exhibited a stronger effect than hedonic and emotional content, with originality displaying the strongest correlation. These results are in line with the literature (Hughes et al., 2019; Sánchez-Fernández & Jiménez-Castillo, 2021).

Sponsorship disclosure is a predictor within the content scope that emerged as a result of the gradual introduction of regulation into the influencer marketing sphere (FTC, 2019). As such, it has gained increased attention among practitioners as to how far it decreases the marketing effectiveness of SMIs. Based on the *meta*-analysis, the relationship between sponsorship disclosure and customer engagement cannot be supported (ρ = 0.03, p = *n.s.*).

Considering ways of display, the quality of SMI content exhibited a positive relationship with customer engagement (ρ = 0.28, $p < 0.001$), while for the quantity of SMI content, the relationship was non-significant (ρ = 0.21, p = *n.s.*). Finally, the language of psychological closeness showed a significant positive correlation with customer engagement (ρ = 0.57, $p = 0.002$).

3.3. Results and discussion of purchase intention

Of the 13 predictors included in the *meta*-analysis, eight were significantly related to purchase intention. Table 4 presents the results of the *meta*-analysis of bivariate correlations.

The account characteristic of number of followers was not significantly correlated with purchase intention (ρ = 0.12, p = *n.s.*), which is counterintuitive. According to the prevailing customer engagement research, customer engagement intention contributes to purchase intention and actual purchases (Pansari & Kumar, 2017; Santini et al., 2020). Therefore, when a predictor reduces customer engagement intention, the same predictor should also negatively impact purchase intention. However, the *meta*-analytic results do not support this. It seems that theories arguing for a positive effect on the number of followers, such as opinion leadership, and theories maintaining a negative effect on the number of followers, as stated above, outweigh each other when it comes to purchase intention. The circumstances in which theory applies are still open for research and require further study (Santini et al., 2020).

Three predictors of SMI personal characteristics—namely, attractiveness (ρ = 0.23, $p < 0.001$), expertise (ρ = 0.18, $p = 0.008$), and credibility (ρ = 0.27, $p = 0.03$)—were significantly positively correlated with purchase intention. This result falls within expectation and confirms recent *meta*-analysis in this field (Han & Balabanis, 2024). From a theoretical perspective, this result further confirms the validity of the classical celebrity attributes (Ohanian, 1991). As such, many researchers agree that these attributes foster persuasion and purchase intention (Ryu & Han, 2021). A significant correlation between trustworthiness (ρ = 0.23, p = *n.s.*) and purchase intention, however, could not be verified. This result is counterintuitive and contradicts the outcome of many researchers who argue for the importance of trustworthiness in SMI marketing effectiveness (Martensen et al., 2018; Wiedmann & von Mettenheim, 2020).

Brand congruence (ρ = 0.24, $p < 0.001$) and similarity (ρ = 0.15, $p < 0.001$) were both significantly positively correlated with purchase intention, but self-congruence was not significantly correlated ($\rho = 0.07$, $p = 0.07$). These results resemble the study outcome by Pradhan et al. (2016) in the celebrity context. They found a significant effect on brand congruence but not on congruence between celebrities and consumers (Pradhan et al., 2016). In the analyses, there was a further differentiation between two dimensions of self-congruence—namely, similarity (also referred to as actual self-congruence) and ideal self-congruence. We found disparate effects for both. In the broader consumer behavior context, Malär et al. (2011) and Tan et al. (2019) arrived at similar disparate results for actual and ideal self-congruence.

Informative and functional content style was significantly correlated with purchase intention (ρ = 0.36, $p < 0.001$), further confirming prior *meta*-analytical study in SMI research (Han & Balabanis, 2024).Within the three predictors under the content scope, only sponsorship disclosure demonstrated a significant negative correlation (ρ = −0.23, $p < 0.001$) with purchase intention. This outcome corroborates the persuasion knowledge model theory, suggesting consumers' negative and defensive reactions to persuasive advertising messages (Evans et al., 2017; Kay et al., 2020; S. S. Lee & Johnson, 2022). The other two predictors, interaction (ρ = 0.09, p = *n.s.*) and intimate disclosure (ρ = 0.18, p = *n.s.*), were not significantly correlated with purchase intention.

Finally, the quality of SMI content as a predictor of ways of display was significantly positively correlated with purchase intention (ρ = 0.42, $p = 0.007$), further highlighting the importance of visual appeal on social media platforms.

4. Implications

4.1 Research contribution

This paper pioneers the integration of qualitative and quantitative reviews in social media and influencer marketing research, significantly contributing to the field by addressing the fundamental question of what factors predict SMI marketing effectiveness. The literature review synthesized existing research and identified both overlaps and

inconsistencies prevalent in the field. It culminated in a generalized framework conceptualizing three categories and seven constructs that influence varying levels of marketing effectiveness through SMIs. Utilizing *meta*-analytical methods led to more consistent conclusions (Grewal et al. 2018). The study confirmed 11 key predictors for customer engagement intention and seven for purchase intention. Specifically, similarity, originality, and language strongly correlated with customer engagement, while the number of followers showed a negative correlation. For purchase intention, the strongest predictors were attractiveness, informative and functional content, and content quality. Finally, a combination of the literature and *meta*-analytical reviews revealed critical focus areas in SMI and influencer research, while also highlighting under-researched topics.

4.2. Practical implications

In recent years, the amount of marketing spending dedicated to influencer marketing has increased (Influencer Marketing Hub, 2024). By addressing the primary concern of marketers, which is how to find effective SMIs, the findings of this paper provide several key implications.

First, the paper informs marketers about the mechanisms explaining SMI marketing effectiveness and offers a framework with factors for evaluation to achieve certain marketing outcomes. Through the narrative review, marketers can gain a brief overview of theories that explain how different factors lead to varying levels of marketing effectiveness. Based on the synthesis of knowledge on the topic and the generalized framework, marketers are provided with a structural concept of how to think about and approach this question. Second, the *meta*-analyses for engagement and purchase intention present a set of key predictors that are important for marketers to compare when selecting SMIs with which to partner. This research suggests that when aiming to increase customer engagement, instead of using a SMI with 1 million followers, it is worthwhile to consider using several SMIs with a lower number of followers, with the sum of their number of followers reaching 1 million. With such strategies, the negative effect of the number of followers is overcome while not scarifying the total number of consumers reached. Furthermore, when selecting SMIs with a lower number of followers, this paper suggests that marketers should focus on similarity, originality, and language to achieve the best engagement results. The risk of heavily relying on follower count as a key selection criterion is the reliability of online data and fraud (Influencer Marketing Hub, 2024). Followers are purchasable, and practitioners should be cautious when using these data for their consideration. If the aim of marketers is more sales-oriented, the focus on the number of followers is less relevant. Instead, attractiveness and informative and high-quality content should become central evaluation criteria. Finally, the results provide clearer guidance and a set of evaluation criteria for marketers when comparing SMIs. Therefore, this paper offers marketers a more structured and efficient approach to increasingly important marketing decisions.

4.3. Limitations and a future research agenda

Despite the growing attention on influencer marketing among practitioners and researchers in recent years, there has been a lack of a systematic review and consolidation of study results on SMI effectiveness. This paper stands out as the first to address this gap by employing both qualitative and quantitative review methods. However, there are several limitations.

First, the scope of this paper is defined by its focus on 93 marketing papers published between 2000 and 2022. The breadth of the review thus shapes the extent of our analysis. Second, the diversity of the dependent variables means that the *meta*-analysis was based on a relatively limited number of studies. This constraint limited the inclusion of certain predictors in the quantitative analyses. Nonetheless, as a pioneering effort to apply *meta*-analytical techniques to this emerging field,

Table 5
Future research agenda.

Themes	Critical observations	Sample research questions
Advancing conceptual clarity in SMI marketing effectiveness research	• Each of the 22 theories reviewed offers a unique perspective on SMI marketing effectiveness predictors. • Further exploration and validation of their boundary conditions and interrelationships are needed. • A significant challenge is the overlap and ambiguity due to the lack of consensus in operational definitions.	*Operationalization inconsistencies:* – How do varying operationalization approaches, e.g., ranging from two to four dimensions for source credibility theory, impact its perceived effectiveness? – In what specific contexts or conditions does each operationalization model demonstrate optimal utility? *Interrelationships among theories* – What specific conditions facilitate interaction effects between paired theoretical frameworks? – Under what circumstances do interaction effects between paired theories fail to manifest?
Uncharted interactions and persistent gaps	• This paper resolves 28 of the 40 addressed inconsistencies. • Validation and resolution of the remaining inconsistencies present significant future research opportunities. • Investigating the interaction effects among all identified predictors remains an unexplored area.	– How do brand congruence and follower count influence consumer attitudes towards a brand? Are there any boundary conditions? – In what ways does the disclosure of sponsorship impact consumer attitudes towards the advertisement? – How do the WHO, WHAT, and HOW predictors interact in the context of SMI marketing? – What implications do these interactions have on the overall effectiveness of SMI marketing strategies?
Distinguishing SMIs from celebrities	• Parallels between SMIs and celebrities as effective endorsers highlight the need for detailed delineation. • Further exploration aims to deepen understanding of specific predictors of SMI marketing effectiveness.	– How do SMI marketing effectiveness theories apply to celebrities? – What are the distinct characteristics of SMI endorsements as opposed to celebrity endorsements in terms of personal-related factors, content creation, and audience engagement? – Beyond understanding their difference, what effects do SMI-celebrity collaborations have on marketing effectiveness? How do predictors behave in this scenario?
Quantitative validation and application of SMI marketing effectiveness framework	• This paper introduces a generalized framework for assessing SMI marketing effectiveness. • Future research should provide additional validation and quantitative assessment.	– Which quantitative methods best assess the SMI framework's reliability and accuracy? – How can the proposed framework be quantitatively aligned with key marketing performance indicators?

(*continued on next page*)

Table 5 (*continued*)

Themes	Critical observations	Sample research questions
		– In what ways can this generalized framework be practically implemented by marketing professionals to evaluate SMI campaigns?

the findings reflect the current state of accumulated research knowledge. Third, the limited dataset precludes the use of *meta*-analytic structural equation modeling to validate causal relationships between predictors and dependent measures of SMI marketing effectiveness. Consequently, understanding the dynamics within the generalized framework of marketing effectiveness remains a challenge for future research.

This paper summarizes four major directions for future research. First, the discussion on theory clusters revealed several questions on the clear demarcation of theories, such as source credibility, opinion leadership, and elaboration likelihood model, and their relationships with each other in explaining expertise. However, there are certain combinations of relationships that have not yet been explored, such as how parasocial relationships with SMI satisfy the need for social interaction from a uses and gratification theory perspective. Second, for several predictors, further research is required to resolve the inconsistencies in the existing findings. For example, the inconsistency of follower count on engagement requires further investigation of the conditions of effect change. In sum, the interaction effects across predictors are still unexplored and could be resolved when enough primary data are available to conduct a *meta*-analytic structural equation modeling approach. The remaining questions concern how moderators for similarity—for example, trustworthiness and closeness—interact in a joint model. For some predictors, such as authenticity, empirical evidence is still limited. For the *meta*-analysis of customer engagement, only two studies were identified. Third, many celebrities have social media accounts with many followers. The similarity between SMIs and celebrities is incontestable. Therefore, there is a need to identify further boundary conditions and delineate how predictors of marketing effectiveness behave in comparisons between SMIs and celebrities. Fourth, based on the existing literature, this paper presents a comprehensive framework for evaluating SMI marketing effectiveness. While this framework is extensive, it requires further validation and quantitative analysis. The development of specific SMI measurement scales, in addition to *meta*-analytical methods, is crucial because such scales would contribute significantly to scholarly discussions and provide tangible tools for marketers. With the rising digitalization and transparency of data that social media platforms provide, such analyses and calculations have become increasingly feasible. Table 5 presents a summary of the key dimensions for future research with sample research questions.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Katja Spörl-Wang: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Franziska Krause:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Supervision, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Conceptualization. **Sven Henkel:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Supervision, Project administration, Methodology, Conceptualization.

Acknowledgment

No acknowledgments.

Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2024.114991.

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